one to use on any given day. If a bat feels good, I will generally keep using it until it breaks. If it feels really good, I won't use it in the nets – just to make it last as long as possible. A bat can last for a week or a month or a year, and I will mark the top of the handle with a 'W' for warm-up and then 1, 2, 3 and 4.

There are quite a few bats in the garage at home, and one of my regrets is that I didn't write on the bats after I played a significant innings. It would be quite good to know which one is which.

Kookaburra has been kindly supplying me with bats ever since 2000, when I was a 16-year-old schoolboy. It's an Australian company, but the brand is distributed in South Africa by JRT Crampton Ltd, and I have always been helped by Chris Bryant, the kindest and most generous man you could ever wish to meet.

It was Chris who signed my first contract all those years ago and, ever since – whatever I have needed, wherever I have been in the world – he has always made sure I have received everything on time. Nowadays, his daughter, Nicola Ludlow, helps to manage the business, and the service remains outstanding.

Chris also provides me with batting gloves, pads and a thigh pad. There are usually six pairs of gloves in my bag because, if possible, I like to use a new pair for every major match, but the same pair of pads and the same thigh pad will see me through an entire season. Every batsman obviously needs to wear a protective box and, in recent years, I have preferred to wear not one, but two boxes fitted together.

Some batsmen choose to wear various forms of arm protection as well. I don't wear anything on my arm because I don't want the bowler to think I'm worried about being hit. However, I always wear a helmet when batting, even when I am facing slow bowlers, because the ball can still ricochet up and hit my face. As far as I am concerned, anyone who decides not to wear a helmet when batting is not brave … they're just stupid.